

WALK ON THE WILD SIDE

The art of wildlife photography, straight from the horse's mouth...

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If there's one Indian wildlife photographer whose work speaks for itself, it is Dhritiman Mukherjee. His stunning images from across the country (and the world) have featured in top outlets like National Geographic, Lonely Planet, WWF, BBC, Daily Mail, The Guardian and Sanctuary Asia. He has won many prestigious awards, including the Royal Bank of Scotland Earth Hero award



A snow leopard stares into Dhritman's lens.

in the 'Inspire' category (2014), the Carl Zeiss Conservation Award (2013) and the Kirloskar Vasundhara Mitra Award. We caught up with him to try and get the inside scoop on the art of wildlife photography.

"I was never an artist, and I'm not one now", says Dhritiman Mukherjee. "What I do is document, and I try to do it in a way that creates inquisitiveness, and a connection between the subject and the viewer. I think it's important to lobby for the natural world. You're not going to want to save something you've never heard of,

seen, or had a connection with. That's what I see myself doing."

BEGINNINGS

Mukherjee's journey began as a teenager. He never liked biology and did his best to avoid it. In a gap year following a graduation in physics, he found himself wanting to do some mountaineering. It was then that he bought a camera, and took up a course in ecology. "No love, no motivation, nothing... I just took the course," says Mukherjee.

He explains his two main reasons for choosing mountains at the time: "Those days, photography was about going to national parks and sanctuaries and shooting the same subject. They were expensive even then, and I had no money. Secondly, mountains were entirely unexplored by photographers, and known only to some researchers. Since mountains were my strength, that's where I began."

In fact, the mountains were so unexplored and unknown, that many in the wildlife community didn't even know that there was an ape species in the Himalayas (the Gibbon) until they saw his photographs! And this was as recently as 2004 or 2005!

SECRETS FOR SUCCESS?

It's not easy work though. Far from it. It takes patience, planning and indepth knowledge of the subject and the terrain, and most importantly, respect for nature. When he set out to capture a shot of a charging one-horned rhinoceros from ground level, it took him two weeks of eight hour days, trudging up and down a 15